hierarchy. The symbolism of having a prime minister who is an OBC leader has been central to the BJP's politics in the Hindi heartland. It is one reason why the party did not need to put in place an OBC chief minister in UP (just as it did not need a Jat chief minister in Haryana or a Maratha chief minister in Maharashtra). UP Deputy Chief Minister Dinesh Sharma explained this by saying, 'We have a Backward leadership. Modiji is, as it is, way above caste, but if people say that they have a Backward leadership, then well, BJP has given the prime minister in the form of Backward leadership. Though we don't talk about this issue, but the public watches everything and knows everything. Because of the way we work, they don't have any counter against our leadership.'[39]

By way of context, India's first and only OBC prime minister before Modi was H.D. Deve Gowda (1996-97), who headed a rickety coalition and became prime minister as a post-election consensus choice between regional parties, not through a national mandate. Modi is the OBC leader who led his party to national election victories, not once but twice. The BJP can credit itself with having the first full-term prime minister from the Mandal classes, twice.

Sharma's response sums up how Modi himself approaches the OBC question in public, though not very often. But when he does, he is very explicit. His messaging is always wrapped up in the larger binary of what he calls the politics of the 'Naamdar' (those with big names, i.e., in his view, the Congress) and 'Kaamdar' (those who work, i.e., in his view, himself). The clearest illustration of this was in Rajasthan's Alwar in November 2018, when he linked the caste debate to Rajiv Gandhi's opposition to the Mandal Commission. As he put it:[40]

Parliament was discussing the Mandal Commission Report in the context of reservations for OBCs and this Naamdar Rajiv Gandhi, just take out the Parliamentary debate records and check—the poison Rajiv Gandhi spat out, the language he used, the criticism he made, the echoes of it can still be heard within the walls of India's Parliament. This is a reflection of their mindset. Brothers and sisters … Among Congress leaders, someone abuses my mother, someone asks questions on my jaati, I am not surprised. Whosoever